

As the first towns became more complex, new ways of communicating within the community and with other sites became important.

WRITTEN COMMUNICATION

By 3100 BCE, written scripts like this one were in use in both Egypt and Mesopotamia. They developed from clay tokens used for recording commercial transactions. Only a few people were literate—scribes who **recorded and controlled all kinds of information** for the state **62–63 >>**.



CUNEIFORM SCRIPT

CENTERS OF TRADE

In Egypt and Mesopotamia, **cities grew rapidly** to become major trading centers, with imposing public buildings. As urban populations rose, cities became the hubs of larger kingdoms and empires. At the same time, the volume of **long-distance trade** in commodities like iron ore and lumber grew quickly, as did the **demand for gold, silver, and other precious materials**.

GROWING AROUND THE YEAR

By 3000 BCE, **irrigation agriculture**, which used simple canals to divert floodwater to crops, began to give way to more elaborate agricultural landscapes with **networks of canals**. These larger areas produced food surpluses that saved labor, allowing rulers to engage in public works such as **pyramid building 56–57, 72–73 >>**.



Enki's shrine, which began as a small mud-brick construction and went through at least six incarnations before becoming an imposing stepped pyramid adorned with brightly colored brick set in a 590-sq-ft (180-m²) enclosure.

The First Egyptian towns

In 4000 BCE, Egypt consisted of a valley of farmers living in small communities spaced along the Nile, which watered

their fields. It was a competitive world of small kingdoms, the largest of which were based on growing towns like Abydos and Nekhen in Upper Egypt. While Abydos was a sacred place—the ancient entrance to the underworld—Nekhen was a major pottery trading center. Nekhen's chieftains may have been the forerunners of the Egyptian rulers called pharaohs (see pp. 56–57), for they are known to have supervised agriculture, and, like later kings, may have been considered living gods.

Town hierarchy

As towns grew, so society became increasingly hierarchical. One can liken these societies to a pyramid. At the top was the ruler, who may have governed as a living god as well as a secular leader. Beneath him were his immediate family and a small privileged class of high officials and priests. Lower down the scale came artisans, lesser functionaries, soldiers, and the commoners who were the manpower upon which all of society depended. Early Sumerian rulers and Egyptian pharaohs ruled by precedent (using the decisions of their predecessors rather than written laws), gave limited public

appearances, and lived in seclusion. Perhaps the very fact that they were not often seen in public led to the perception that they had supernatural powers.

A divine ruler's power came from his ability to control the labor of thousands of commoners. His authority came not only from a threat of force, but also from pervasive ideas and religious beliefs commemorated by art and writing on temple walls and reinforced by elaborate ceremonies. The latter were often displays of power that required imposing settings and conspicuous burial places such as pyramids.

For reasons that are still not fully understood, by the end of the 4th millennium BCE in Mesopotamia, almost everyone lived in cities. This was a rapidly changing world where wealth assumed increasing

importance. Life in early towns was unsanitary and chaotic with people living at close quarters.

Egyptian towns

In Egypt, town dwellers—even high officials—maintained close ties to relatives in areas surrounding the town. Little detail is known about the first Egyptian towns, which developed toward the end of the 4th millennium BCE, but they probably began as connected groups of growing villages. Different communities came together, perhaps for defensive reasons, under the rule of charismatic rulers.

Some early Egyptian towns, such as Nekhen, became important trading centers and river ports, ruled by chiefs who competed with their neighbors. The roots of many of the most important cities in civilization began at this time.



Palette of Narmer

Dating to c. 3000 BCE, this slate palette, from a temple at Hierakonpolis, appears to show an early king and the unification of Upper and Lower Egypt.

FIRST EGYPTIAN RULER

HORUS AHA

King Horus Aha, often called Menes, is a shadowy figure in Egyptian history. He became the first ruler of a unified Egypt in about 3000 BCE. His predecessor, Narmer, an Upper Egyptian chieftain, may have unified Egypt with decisive military victories, but it was Horus Aha who assumed the role of divine king, the living god Horus on Earth. Like other early pharaohs, Horus Aha was buried at Abydos in Upper Egypt (see pp. 64–65). His power came from prowess in war and control of lucrative trade routes with Lower Egypt, even Mesopotamia.